changed completely and the security concerns related to it needed to be addressed urgently.

After his release, Maulana Azhar formed a terror outfit named Jaish-e-Mohammed that aimed to unite Kashmir with Pakistan. The outfit, the R&AW suspected, had deep links in Nepal. The shadowy war was being fought on twin fronts—taking out terrorists and sleeper cells as well as helping Nepal tackle the growing menace of the Maoist movement that used hit squads to target infrastructure and was tying up with Indian insurgents.

The Maoists' overground leadership though, had developed an incredibly close connection with the Indian intelligence agency. An agent runner codenamed Nirmal Khatri said that they knew practically everyone in the cadre. Khatri and a handful of trusted men identified assets in the cadre for use in future operations. But sometime in 2000-2001, everything just collapsed. This was largely due to the one-way policy of the government, which believed that supporting just the Nepalese Congress was the wisest thing to do. And so it stopped cultivating Nepalese Marxists. In Kha-tri's words, 'It was the beginning of hostility towards India as we did not expand our network among the Marxists.'

Khatri said that while the R&AW argued strongly in support of the Maoist leadership, the NDA government headed by Atal Bihari Vajpayee had a different take on the issue. The then defence minister, George Fernandes, even went on record to say, 'The fight against Nepalese Maoists is also India's fight.' This perturbed many Nepalese Maoist leaders, who had been getting covert support from the R&AW.